Rule of Ommiad or Umayyad dynasty

The Caliphs, belonging to a branch of Mohammad's family, known as Ommiads or Umayyads ruled for about 100 years. Damascus was their capital. They developed a new style of architecture known as Saracenic architecture. The arches, the pillars, and the minarets and domes came to India later and blended with Indian ideas.



Saracenic Architecture

The Muslim Arabs carried Islam far and wide. But while they were fighting at distant lands, the Arabs at home were quarrelling. Ali, the son-in-law of Prophet Mohammad and his son Hussein were murdered. **Umayyads** were overthrown by Abbasids. This branch descended from Prophet Mohammad's uncle Abbas and hence his followers were called Abbasids.

Rule of Abbasids

Abbasid rule began in 750 A.D. (C.E.) assuming the title of "the Commander of the Faithful", Abbasid Caliph wielded authority as any other Emperor. The Abbasids tried to rival the old empires in splendour. The capital was shifted from Damascus to Baghdad in Iraq.



Baghdad City

Baghdad- a city known as the city of Arabian Nights, 'was a vast city of palaces and public offices and schools and colleges, and great shops and parks and gardens. The merchants carried on a vast trade with the East and West.... Visitors came to Baghdad from all over the world, especially learned men and students and artists Nehru, Gl*impses of World History.*

Arabs' Scholarly Pursuits

Abbasid Caliphs did not attempt to conquer new lands. Instead they tried to consolidate the Empire. They were more interested in scholarly pursuits. The A r abs h a d a scientific spirit of inquiry. In some subjects like medicine and mathematics they learnt much more from India. Many students from Arabia went to Taxila to learn Medical Education, By that time Taxila was a popular Medical University. Indian scholars and mathematicians came in large numbers to Baghdad. Sanskrit books on medicine and other subjects were translated into Arabic. In medicine and surgery, Arab physicians and surgeons earned a great reputation.

6.3 (b) Disintegration of Arab Empire and Rise of Seljuq Turks

The Abbasid Empire was at the height of its glory during the reign of Harun-al-Rashid. Soon after his death, the Arab Empire started disintegrating. Independent kingdoms arose everywhere. The Caliph became more and more powerless to control those kingdoms. The Turks (known as Seljuq Turks), who had become Muslims, succeeded in taking possession of Baghdad. They also defeated the Byzantine army of Constantinople and posed a challenge to the European states. The Christian pilgrims to the holy city of Jerusalem were put to a lot of hardships by the Turks. The resultant conflict led to the Crusades.

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